



SWEDEN

Capital city: Stockholm
Area: 173,371 sq miles (449,964 sq km)
Population: 8,900,000
Official language: Swedish
Major religions: Christian 85%, other 15%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Swedish krona
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 78 years
People per doctor: 370
Televisions: 470 per 1,000 people

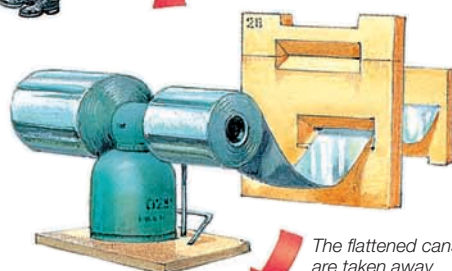
SWEDEN

LYING BETWEEN NORWAY and Finland, Sweden stretches from the Arctic north to the fertile south, where most of its small population lives. Sweden's long industrial traditions and a highly skilled workforce have made it one of the world's most advanced manufacturing countries. Like its neighbors, Sweden is a prosperous place, where equal rights for all groups in society are taken very seriously.

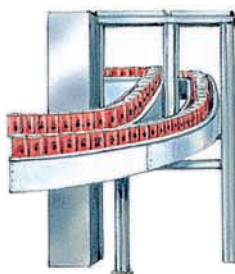


Recycling system

Customers return their empty aluminum cans to stores with machines that flatten the cans, allowing many more to be collected.



The flattened cans are taken away, melted down, and rolled into new sheets of aluminum.



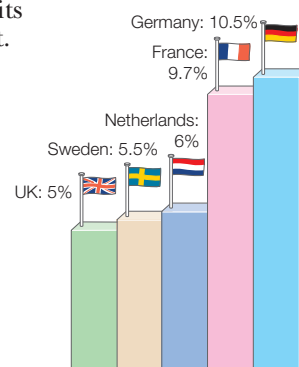
Soon, brand new cans made from the sheets are rolling off the production line, ready to start the cycle all over again.



SOCIAL WELFARE

Sweden has led the way in social welfare, and a small population has made it easy for the government to take care of everyone. Child care and facilities for the sick and the elderly are excellent. Unemployment figures have been relatively low (see chart below). However, to pay for these benefits the government must impose high taxes. Also, current economic problems have put some of the benefits under threat.

Percentage of unemployed people (2004 figures)



CONSERVATION

Swedes are very concerned about conserving their environment. This includes their historic buildings as well as the countryside. There are many nature reserves in Sweden and some of Europe's largest national parks in the mountainous north. Many people are worried about water pollution and Sweden is a leading campaigner in the movement to clean up the Baltic Sea. It has also restricted industrial development in some coastal areas. Conserving resources is part of everyday life and Sweden runs a highly successful recycling system (right).



SUMMER HOMES

Vacation homes are common in this wealthy country. Pretty wooden houses, often painted red, are found along the coast, lakeshores, and in river valleys. They provide the perfect escape for city dwellers on weekends or during vacations. When they are not there themselves, families often rent these retreats out to friends or to the growing number of tourists to Sweden.

DESIGN

Sweden is renowned for the simple lines of its design, which is copied all over the world. Swedish designers began to make an impact in the 1960s. Good design has helped sell cars, electrical equipment, textiles, and furniture.



This Swedish office chair is designed to be comfortable and practical.



SMÖRGÅSBORD

Smörgås means a slice of bread and *bord* is the Swedish word for table, but this Scandinavian specialty is much more than a table of sandwiches. It usually refers to a vast buffet of tempting cold foods, such as herrings in mustard sauce, various cheeses, meats, and salads.

Find out more

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